



INSTAMAPS FOR UPSC CSE: IMPORTANT PLACES IN NEWS IN INDIA & THE WORLD

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WORLD:

BALTIC SEA



- The Baltic Sea is a semi-enclosed, shallow, brackish water body and an arm of the [North Atlantic Ocean](#), making it the largest expanse of brackish water in the world. It has historically served as a major trade and strategic maritime corridor in northern Europe.

Located in: Northern Europe

- Extends from southern Denmark in the southwest to near the Arctic Circle in the north
- Connected to the North Sea through narrow straits such as the [Øresund](#), [Great Belt](#) and [Little Belt](#).

Bordering nations: The [Baltic Sea](#) is bordered by **nine countries**:

- Denmark, Sweden, Finland, Russia, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland and Germany.
- Eight of these are **NATO members**, adding to its geopolitical significance.

Key features:

- Low salinity (brackish water):** Due to limited connection with the North Sea and large freshwater inflow from rivers like the Vistula and Oder.
- Shallow seabed:** Makes undersea cables and pipelines vulnerable to damage and sabotage.
- Sub-regions:** Includes the [Gulf of Finland](#), Gulf of Bothnia, Gulf of Riga, and straits like Kattegat and Skagerrak.
- Strategic infrastructure hub:** Hosts critical energy pipelines, power cables and telecom links.
- Cold climate and seasonal ice:** Parts of the sea freeze in winter, especially in the Gulfs of Bothnia and Finland.

THE RED SEA



- The Red Sea is a long, narrow sea forming part of a major rift system, known for high salinity, warm waters, and rich coral reef ecosystems.

Located in:

- It extends southeast from **Suez (Egypt)** to the [Bab el-Mandeb Strait](#), connecting the Mediterranean (via the Suez Canal) to the Arabian Sea through the Gulf of Aden.

Bordering nations: Egypt, Sudan, Eritrea, Saudi Arabia, Yemen

Key features:

- Formed by continental rifting between the African and Arabian plates.
- Includes the [Gulf of Suez](#) (shallow) and Gulf of Aqaba (deep, narrow).
- Characterised by fringing coral reefs, deep axial troughs, volcanic islands, and hot brine pools rich in minerals.

ARABIAN SEA



- The Arabian Sea is a northwestern arm of the [Indian Ocean](#), forming a crucial maritime space linking Europe, West Asia, Africa, and South Asia, and serving as one of the world's busiest sea routes.

Bordering nations:

- India, Pakistan, Iran, Oman, Yemen, and Somalia.
- Connected to the [Persian Gulf](#) via the Strait of

Hormuz and to the Red Sea via the Bab-el-Mandeb Strait.

Key geological features:

- Formed ~50 million years ago due to the collision of the Indian Plate with Eurasia.
- Dominated by deep basins:** [Arabian Basin](#) and Somali Basin.
- Presence of Carlsberg Ridge and Murray Ridge – seismically active submarine ridges.
- Upwelling zones along Somali and Arabian coasts during the southwest monsoon.

VENEZUELA



- Venezuela is a federal multiparty republic in **northern South America**, historically shaped by oil-led growth and, since 1999, by a socialist political project begun under Hugo Chávez and continued by Nicolás Maduro.

Location: Northern end of South America, with coastlines on the [Caribbean Sea](#) and Atlantic Ocean.

Capital: Caracas.

Neighbouring countries: Caribbean Sea, Guyana, Brazil and Colombia.

- Venezuela also administers several Caribbean islands (e.g., Margarita, Los Roques) and has a long-running territorial dispute with Guyana over the Essequibo region.

Key features:

- Andes Mountains:** In the northwest (Cordillera de Mérida), including Bolívar Peak.
- Lake Maracaibo Basin:** One of South America's major oil-producing regions.
- Llanos:** Vast tropical plains along the Orinoco River, important for cattle and hydrocarbons.
- Guiana Highlands:** Ancient crystalline uplands in the southeast with **tepui** (tabletop mountains) and **Angel Falls**, the world's highest waterfall.
- Orinoco River System:** Drains most of the country and anchors its ecological and economic geography.

IRAN



- Iran is located in **southwestern Asia**, acting as a bridge between the Middle East, Central Asia, and South Asia, and commanding strategic access to the Persian Gulf and the Strait of Hormuz.

Capital: Tehran.

Neighbouring nations: Azerbaijan, Armenia, Turkmenistan, Caspian Sea, Afghanistan, Pakistan, Turkey, Iraq, Persian Gulf and [Gulf of Oman](#).

Key geological and physical features:

- Central Iranian Plateau:** A vast, arid and elevated region forming Iran's core, dominated by the Dasht-e Kavir and Dasht-e Lut deserts, characterised by extreme temperatures, salt flats, and sparse habitation.
- Zagros Mountains:** A long northwest–southeast mountain system in western Iran.
- Alborz Mountains:** Running along the southern Caspian Sea coast.
- High seismic activity:** Located at the convergence of the Arabian and Eurasian tectonic plates, Iran experiences frequent and often devastating earthquakes.
- Drainage and rivers:** the [Karun River](#) in the southwest is the only fully navigable river and a crucial source of irrigation and hydroelectric power.

GREENLAND



- Greenland (Kalaallit Nunaat) is the world's largest island and a self-governing territory with extensive

internal autonomy, while remaining within the Kingdom of Denmark.

Located in:

- North Atlantic Ocean and Arctic region
- Largely within the [Arctic Circle](#), between North America and Europe

Key geological features:

- **Greenland Ice Sheet:** Covers about **80% of the island**, second only to Antarctica, and a critical indicator of global climate change.
- **Ancient shield rocks:** Geologically part of the [Canadian Shield](#), composed mainly of Precambrian rocks.
- **Fjords and glaciers:** Deeply indented coastlines with fast-moving outlet glaciers such as **Jakobshavn Glacier**.
- **Resource potential:** Significant deposits of rare earth elements, critical minerals, and hydrocarbons.

Currently governed by:

- Denmark retains control over defence, foreign affairs, and currency.
- Greenland's elected government manages domestic affairs, under the Self-Rule Act (2009), which recognises the [right to self-determination](#).

Limits under international law:

- [UN Charter](#) (Article 2(4)) prohibits acquisition of territory by threat or use of force.
- Any territorial transfer requires free, voluntary consent of the concerned sovereign state(s) and the people of Greenland.
- Annexation or coerced cession is considered illegal under modern international law.

VICTORIA STATE



- Victoria is a state in southeastern Australia, known for its diverse landscapes, economic importance, and political influence. It is the second-most populous Australian state after New South Wales.

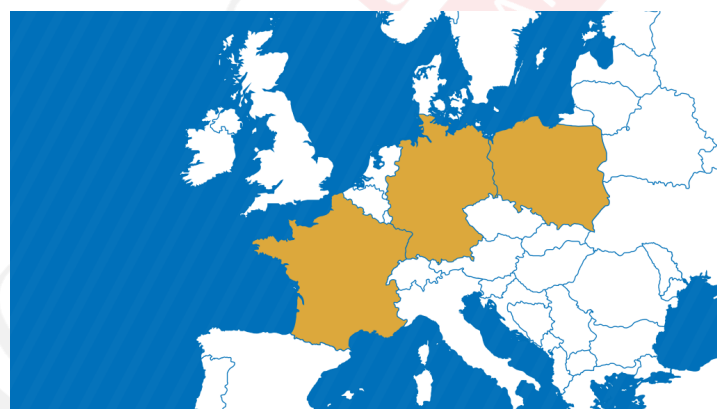
Location:

- Situated in **southeastern Australia**
- Lies between [temperate coastal zones](#) and inland semi-arid regions
- Faces the Tasman Sea and Southern Ocean along its southern coastline

Bordering states: New South Wales (separated largely by the Murray River), South Australia, Southern Ocean and Tasman Sea.

Capital city: Melbourne, located on [Port Phillip Bay](#), is Australia's major cultural, educational, and financial hub.

WEIMAR TRIANGLE



- The Weimar Triangle is a trilateral political and diplomatic grouping of France, Germany and Poland created to promote European integration, political dialogue and security cooperation, especially in matters concerning Russia and [Eastern Europe](#).

Established in: 1991

- Named after the city of Weimar (Germany), where the three foreign ministers first met.

Members: France, Germany and Poland.

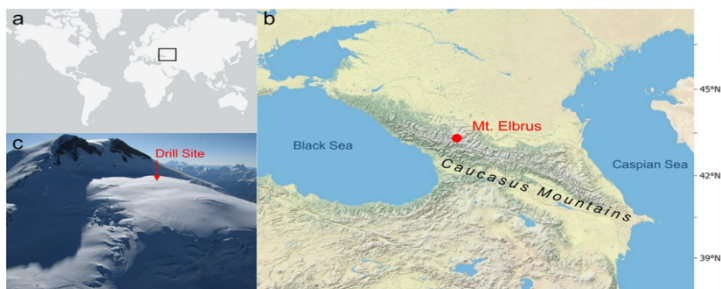
Aim:

- To build a united and secure Europe by strengthening political, security and economic cooperation among Western and [Central European powers](#), particularly in response to Russia and regional conflicts.

Key functions:

- **European political coordination:** Aligns positions on major EU foreign policy, security and defence issues.
- **Security and Ukraine policy:** Plays a key role in coordinating responses to Russia and supporting Ukraine.
- **Strategic dialogue:** Enables pre-summit consultations before major EU and NATO meetings.
- **Reconciliation and integration:** Originally helped integrate Poland into [NATO](#) (1999) and the EU (2004).
- **Trilateral cooperation:** Promotes joint initiatives in diplomacy, defence, economy and culture.

MOUNT ELBRUS



- Mount Elbrus is the highest mountain in Europe and an ancient, extinct volcano with two distinct peaks (East and West).
- It is part of the [Caucasus mountain system](#) and a major centre for mountaineering and alpine tourism.

Located in:

- Southwestern Russia, in the Caucasus Mountains, just north of the Georgia border.
- Lies between the Black Sea and the [Caspian Sea mountain](#) corridor.

Key geological features:

- A twin-coned stratovolcano formed over 2.5 million years ago.
- Highest peak reaches 5,642 metres, the second peak 5,595 metres.
- Covered by 22 glaciers, which feed rivers like the [Kuban](#) and Terek.
- Though dormant for nearly 2,000 years, sulphurous gases and mineral springs are still present.

BULGARIA JOINS EUROZONE

Bulgaria officially adopted the euro on January 1, 2026, becoming the 21st member of the [eurozone](#) and retiring its national currency, the lev.



- Bulgaria is a Balkan nation in southeastern Europe and a member of the European Union (since 2007) and [NATO](#) (since 2004). It replaced the Bulgarian lev (in use since 1881) with the euro after fulfilling EU

convergence criteria.

Location: Located in the eastern Balkan Peninsula, Bulgaria sits at the crossroads of Europe, the Black Sea region, and West Asia, giving it strategic geopolitical importance.

Bordering nations: Romania, Greece, Turkey, Serbia, North Macedonia and Black Sea.

Geographical features:

- Danubian Plain in the north (fertile agricultural belt).
- [Balkan Mountains](#) running east–west.
- Rila–Rhodope Massif in the south (Mount Musala – highest peak in the Balkans).
- Black Sea coastline supporting ports, tourism, and trade.

About Eurozone:

- The eurozone (euro area) is the group of EU countries that have adopted the euro (€) as their official legal tender and follow a common monetary policy.

Established in:

- **1992 – Maastricht Treaty:** Formally created the Economic and Monetary Union (EMU), setting convergence criteria and a legal roadmap for a single currency to ensure fiscal discipline and macroeconomic stability among EU states.

Members

- **21 EU countries** (as of 2026), including Germany, France, Italy, Spain, Greece, Croatia (2023), and **Bulgaria (2026)**.

Key features:

- Single currency (euro) as legal tender.
- [European Central Bank](#) (ECB) conducts unified monetary policy.
- No currency exchange costs within the bloc.
- Free movement of goods, services, capital, and labour.
- Members get representation on the ECB Governing Council.

MUNA ISLAND



- Muna Island is a large island in Southeast [Sulawesi Province](#), Indonesia, known for its limestone landscapes, archaeological richness, and Austronesian cultural heritage. It is administratively divided into Muna, West Muna, and Central Buton regencies.

Location:

- Situated south-east of Sulawesi and west of Buton Island
- Lies in the Flores Sea, along the Wallacea biogeographical zone—a key corridor between Sunda (Asia) and Sahul (Australia–New Guinea).

Key geological features:

- Dominated by [limestone karst formations](#) with caves and rock shelters.
- Presence of **speleothems (calcium carbonate deposits)**, which enabled **U-series dating** of cave art.
- Hilly terrain with elevations up to ~445 metres.

INDIA:

BARGI DAM



- Bargi Dam is a major multipurpose dam built for irrigation, drinking water supply and hydroelectric power generation.

Located in: It is located in Jabalpur district of Madhya Pradesh.

River associated: The dam is constructed on the [Narmada River](#).

History:

- Bargi Dam was constructed as part of the [Narmada Valley Development Project](#), which aimed to harness the Narmada River for irrigation, hydropower and water supply.

HOOGHLY RIVER



- The Hooghly River (also spelled Hugli) is a major distributary of the [Ganga River](#) system in West Bengal, serving as a crucial lifeline for navigation, industry, and urban settlements, including Kolkata.

Origin:

- Formed at Nabadwip by the junction of the Bhagirathi and Jalangi rivers.
- The Bhagirathi itself is a distributary of the Ganga, making [Hooghly part](#) of the Ganga deltaic system.

Flow through:

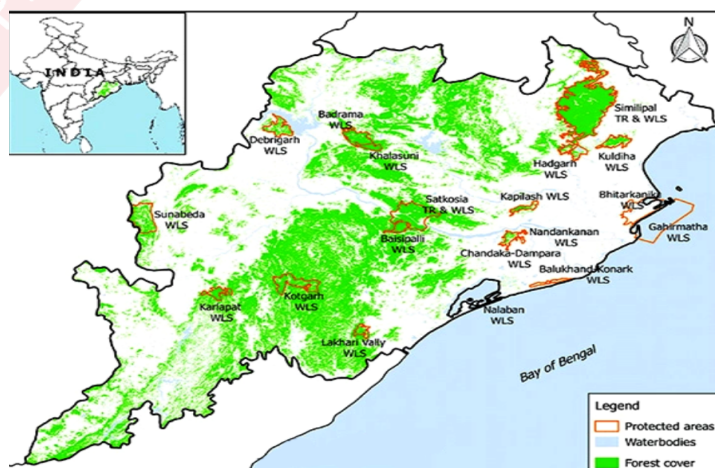
- Flows southward through Nadia, Hooghly, Howrah, Kolkata, and South 24 Parganas districts.
- Empties into the [Bay of Bengal](#) via a wide estuary.

Tributaries: Ajay, Damodar, Rupnarayan, and Haldi

Hooghly is a tributary of:

- The Ganga River (it is a distributary arm providing access from the Bay of Bengal to inland Kolkata).

SIMILIPAL NATIONAL PARK



- Similipal is a National Park, Tiger Reserve and [Biosphere Reserve](#) forming part of the Mayurbhanj Elephant Reserve.
- It is one of India's most biodiverse protected landscapes and is part of the UNESCO [World Network of Biosphere Reserves](#) (since 2009).

Location:

- Located in Mayurbhanj district of northern Odisha, it lies in the Eastern Ghats and spreads over about 2,750 sq km, making it one of India's largest tiger reserves.

KUMBHALGARH WILDLIFE SANCTUARY

The Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change has notified the Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary as an [Eco-Sensitive Zone](#) (ESZ) to strengthen conservation in the [Aravalli Range](#).

- Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary is a protected wildlife reserve known for its dry deciduous forest ecosystem and rich [faunal diversity](#), surrounding the historic Kumbhalgarh Fort.

Located in:

- Rajasthan, spread across Rajsamand, Udaipur, and Pali districts.
- Part of the Aravalli hill system in western India.

Geological features:

- Falls under the **Khathiar–Gir dry deciduous forest ecoregion**, supporting scrub forests, grasslands, and woodland species.
- Fauna:** Leopard (apex predator), Indian wolf, sloth bear, striped hyena, jungle cat, golden jackal, sambhar, nilgai, chausingha, chinkara, Indian hare, Indian pangolin.
- Avifauna:** Grey junglefowl, painted francolin, Indian eagle-owl.
- Herpetofauna & aquatic life:** Indian cobra, rat snake, checkered keelback; fish like mahseer, rohu, katla.

PANGOLAKHA WILDLIFE SANCTUARY

IMPORTANT BIRD AREAS AND WILDLIFE PROTECTED AREAS



- Pangolakha Wildlife Sanctuary is a high-altitude protected area and a designated [Important Bird Area](#) (IBA), known for its exceptional alpine to subtropical biodiversity and strategic location along

India's eastern Himalayan frontier.

Located in: East Sikkim, Sikkim.

Neighbouring states / nations

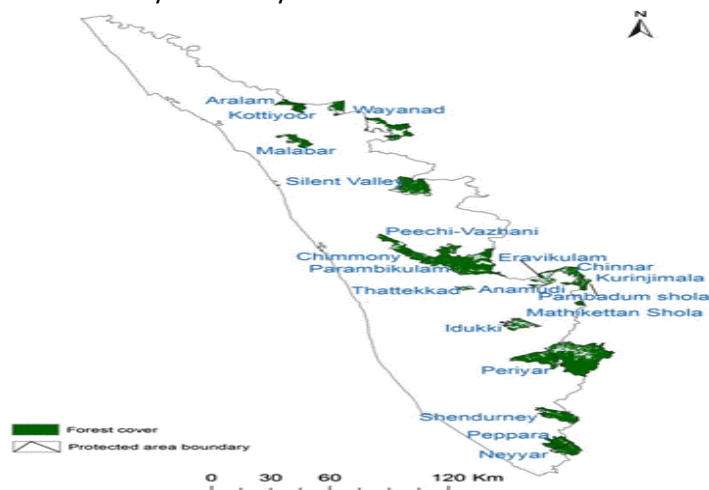
- Bhutan to the east
- China ([Tibet Autonomous Region](#)) to the north (via Nathu La–Jelep La corridor)
- Extends southwards towards West Bengal, connecting with Neora Valley National Park

Key features:

- Unique biogeography:**
 - Part of the **Eastern Himalayas biodiversity hotspot**
 - Encompasses **three biomes**:
 - Eurasian High Montane (Alpine & Tibetan)
 - Sino-Himalayan Temperate Forest
 - Sino-Himalayan Subtropical Forest
- Rich flora:**
 - [Rhododendron forests](#), Silver Fir, Juniper, oak forests with dense bamboo thickets
 - Alpine pastures and high-altitude wetlands such as **Bedang Tso Lake**
- Diverse fauna:**
 - Tiger, Leopard, Takin, Musk Deer, Goral, Serow, Asiatic Black Bear
 - Himalayan Monal, Snow Partridge, Pallas's Fish Eagle, Wood Snipe (Vulnerable), Tibetan Eared Pheasant (Near Threatened)
 - Acts as a migratory corridor via Nathu La and Jelep La passes

ARALAM BUTTERFLY SANCTUARY

The Kerala government has officially renamed [Aralam Wildlife Sanctuary](#) as Aralam Butterfly Sanctuary, making it the first butterfly sanctuary in Kerala.



About Aralam Butterfly Sanctuary:

- A protected area in the Western Ghats, now exclu-

sively recognised as Kerala's first butterfly sanctuary, dedicated to the conservation of butterfly species and their habitats.

Located in: Kannur district, Kerala, on the western slopes of the [Western Ghats](#), bordering Brahmagiri Wildlife Sanctuary (Karnataka) and adjoining Kottiyoor Wildlife Sanctuary.

FIRST OPEN-SEA MARINE FISH FARMING PROJECT IN ANDAMAN SEA

India has launched its first open-sea marine fish farming project in the Andaman Sea, marking a major step in advancing the [Blue Economy](#) through science-led, livelihood-oriented utilisation of ocean resources.



- India's first pilot open-sea aquaculture initiative involving marine finfish and seaweed farming in natural oceanic conditions using indigenously developed open-sea cages and marine technologies.

Located in

- North Bay, near Sri Vijaya Puram, Andaman Sea.
- Union Territory of Andaman & Nicobar Islands.

Implementing agencies

- Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES) & [National Institute of Ocean Technology](#) (NIOT).

Aim: To unlock ocean-based economic potential, generate sustainable coastal livelihoods, and build technical

About Andaman Sea:

- The Andaman Sea is a marginal sea of the northeastern Indian Ocean, historically significant for trade and strategically important for maritime connectivity and regional ecology.

Located in: The Andaman Sea is located in the north-eastern Indian Ocean, adjoining South-East Asia.

Bordering: [Irrawaddy River delta](#), Myanmar and Thailand, Sumatra (Indonesia) and the Strait of Malacca.

SHAKSGAM VALLEY



- Shaksgam Valley, also called the Trans-Karakoram Tract, is a high-altitude, sparsely inhabited region in the extreme north of the former princely state of [Jammu and Kashmir](#), claimed by India but administered by China after being transferred by Pakistan.

Located in:

- North of the Siachen Glacier
- Between the Karakoram and Kunlun mountain ranges
- Lies in [Pakistan-occupied Kashmir](#) (Hunza-Gilgit region) but administered by China as part of Xinjiang (Taxkorgan and Yecheng counties)